

## “A CELEBRATION OF LIBERTY”

TEXT: **John 8:31-36** “To the Jews who had believed him, Jesus said, “If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples. <sup>32</sup>Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free.” <sup>33</sup>They answered him, “We are Abraham's descendants and have never been slaves of anyone. How can you say that we shall be set free?” <sup>34</sup>Jesus replied, “I tell you the truth, everyone who sins is a slave to sin. <sup>35</sup>Now a slave has no permanent place in the family, but a son belongs to it forever. <sup>36</sup>So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed.”

INTRO: Yesterday, Saturday July 4, 1998 we just celebrated our 222nd birthday as a free people in the USA

In preparation for this message, I was reminded once again of the “DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE”. As I reflected on this document I began to think how grateful I am to be an American, and to know first hand the meaning of freedom and “LIBERTY”!

I am grateful to the God who has given us freedom, and to the people who have sacrificed and even died to buy and preserve this “LIBERTY”.

In speaking of “LIBERTY”, there’s a song entitled “THE STATUE OF LIBERTY” by Neil Enlow and I want us to hear it’s words; “IN NEW YORK HARBOR STANDS A LADY WITH A TORCH RAISED TO THE SKY. AND ALL WHO SEE HER KNOW SHE STANDS FOR LIBERTY FOR YOU AND ME. I’M SO PROUD TO BE CALLED AN AMERICAN, TO BE NAMED WITH THE BRAVE AND THE FREE! I WILL HONOR OUR FLAG AND OUR TRUST IN GOD, AND THE STATUE OF LIBERTY. ON LONELY GOLGOTHA STOOD A CROSS WITH MY LORD RAISED TO THE SKY, AND ALL WHO KNEEL THERE LIVE FOREVER, AS ALL THE SAVED CAN TESTIFY. I’M SO GLAD TO BE CALLED A CHRISTIAN, TO BE NAMED WITH THE RANSOMED AND WHOLE! AS THE STATUE LIBERATES THE CITIZEN, SO THE CROSS LIBERATES THE SOUL! OH THE CROSS IS MY STATUE OF LIBERTY. IT WAS THERE THAT MY SOUL WAS SET FREE! UNASHAMED I’LL PROCLAIM THAT A RUGGED

CROSS, IS MY STATUE OF LIBERTY.”

As we “CELEBRATE LIBERTY”, I believe there are some things about the “STATUE OF LIBERTY” that we as Christians can identify with in this good fight of the faith!

## I. THE STATUE OF LIBERTY

A. The “STATUE OF LIBERTY”, is a huge copper statue that stands on “LIBERTY” Island, in New York harbor.

It’s proper name is “LIBERTY ENLIGHTENING THE WORLD”. France gave the monument of the U.S. in 1884 as a symbol of friendship between the two nations.

Notice what the Statue of Liberty represents; 1) “THE STATUE OF LIBERTY” symbolizes the “LIBERTY” and brotherhood that citizens of a country enjoy under a free form of Government. Notice our text, **John 8:31-36** “To the Jews who had believed him, Jesus said, "If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples. <sup>32</sup>Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free." <sup>33</sup>They answered him, "We are Abraham's descendants and have never been slaves of anyone. How can you say that we shall be set free?" <sup>34</sup>Jesus replied, "I tell you the truth, everyone who sins is a slave to sin. <sup>35</sup>Now a slave has no permanent place in the family, but a son belongs to it forever. <sup>36</sup>So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed."

2) “THE STATUE OF LIBERTY” is a proud woman dressed in a loose robe that falls in graceful folds to the base of the pedestal on which the statue stands.

Thank God we had someone to stand one day to not only represent freedom for us, but to actually, singlehandedly win our freedom, and “LIBERTY”, his name is “JESUS”.

3) The right arm holds a great torch raised high in the air. At night, the torch in the right hand gleams with powerful fluorescent lights. Thus it stands as a symbol of “LIBERTY” shedding light upon the world.

John Speaking of Jesus, said, John **1:4** “In him was life, and that life was the light of men.”

**John 1:5** “The light shines in the darkness, but the darkness has not understood it.”

How sad, but it is happening all around us today.

We are to help light up the world for Jesus! **Matthew 5:14-16**  
“You are the light of the world. A city on a hill cannot be hidden. <sup>15</sup>Neither do people light a lamp and put it under a bowl. Instead they put it on its stand, and it gives light to everyone in the house. <sup>16</sup>In the same way, let your light shine before men, that they may see your good deeds and praise your Father in heaven.”

Let’s let our light shine.

4) “THE STATUE OF LIBERTY” also serves as a lighthouse for ships, and as a beacon light for airplanes.

Sinner friend in the midst of the storm of your LIFE. JESUS will be the guiding light to safety. **John 3:16** “For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life.”

Satan would like nothing better than to capsize your vessel in the midst of the storm, on the sea of life! I am here to tell you that if you will hold to God’s unchanging hand he will guide you to safety!

5) “THE NEW COLOSSUS” by Emma Lazarus was inscribed on a tablet in the pedestal of the statue in 1908.

Let me read you an excerpt from that;

“Give me your tired, your poor, your huddled masses yearning to breathe free, the wretched refuse of your teeming shore. Send these, the homeless, tempest-tossed to me, I lift my lamp beside the golden door.”

The heartbeat of God is “save sinners”.

6) The left arm of the “STATUE” grasps a tablet which bears the date of the “DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE”.

The disciples had just cast the devil out of a person, and they were rejoicing but Jesus says to them, **Luke 10:20** “...Do not rejoice that the spirits submit to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven.”

Rev. 3:5 Christ says through John, “He who overcomes will, like them, be dressed in white. I will never blot out his name from the book of life, but will acknowledge his name before my Father and his angels.”

Thank God I can know I got my name written there in the spring of 1973.

7) At the “STATUE’S” feet, but seldom noticed, is a broken shackle. It symbolizes a people winning the victory.

After God had instituted the Tabernacle in the wilderness he told Israel. **Leviticus 26:13**

“I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of Egypt so that you would no longer be slaves to the Egyptians; I broke the bars of your yoke and enabled you to walk with heads held high.”

**Psalm 107:13-16** “Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he saved them from their distress. <sup>14</sup>He brought them out of darkness and the deepest gloom and broke away their chains.

<sup>15</sup>Let them give thanks to the Lord for his unfailing love and his wonderful deeds for men,

<sup>16</sup>for he breaks down gates of bronze and cuts through bars of iron.”

**Romans 8:31-39** “What, then, shall we say in response to this? If God is for us, who can be against us? <sup>32</sup>He who did not

spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all--how will he not also, along with him, graciously give us all things? <sup>33</sup>Who will bring any charge against those whom God has chosen? It is God who justifies. <sup>34</sup>Who is he that condemns? Christ Jesus, who died--more than that, who was raised to life--is at the right hand of God and is also interceding for us. <sup>35</sup>Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or hardship or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword? <sup>36</sup>As it is written:"For your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered." <sup>37</sup>No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us. <sup>38</sup>For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, <sup>39</sup>neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

8) A crown with huge spikes, like sun rays, rest on the head of "LADY LIBERTY"!

We one day will obtain an Incorruptible crown.

**1 Cor. 9:25** "Everyone who competes in the games goes into strict training. They do it to get a crown that will not last; but we do it to get a crown that will last forever."

We will obtain a crown of righteousness. (Crown of Innocence, crown of justification).

**2 Tim. 4:8** "Now there is in store for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will award to me on that day--and not only to me, but also to all who have longed for his appearing."

Righteousness = the state of doing the right thing.

We will receive the crown of life. **James 1:12**

"Blessed is the man who perseveres under trial, because when he has stood the test, he will receive the crown of life that God has promised to those who love him." We will live forever!

We will receive the crown of Glory. **1 Peter 5:4** "And when the Chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the crown of glory that will

never fade away.” GLORY=Dignity, honor, praise, worship.

These crowns are to be guarded. If we ever hope to receive them. **Rev. 3:11** “I am coming soon. Hold on to what you have, so that no one will take your crown.”

We will one day cast all these crowns at the feet of the one who died for us. **Rev. 4:10-11**

“the twenty-four elders fall down before him who sits on the throne, and worship him who lives for ever and ever. They lay their crowns before the throne and say: You are worthy, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they were created and have their being.”